accumulated at Tsangdhar, to say nothing of the required artillery support. The earliest any offensive action could be considered, he confided, was the middle of 1963. However, even though Umrao Singh was fully in agreement with his subordinate commanders, he knew that convincing the Eastern Army Commander and the political-military circus in South Block was not going to be easy. Before he left Lumpu, the general had a final meeting with the two commanding officers of 2 Rajput and 1/9 GR, Lieutenant Colonels Rikh and Ahluwalia.

After the conflict, Rikh recorded in his notes: 'When we met the Corps Commander we both felt as if he was saying goodbye to two gladiators who were about to enter the arena never to come out alive. We both assured the Corps Commander that whatever we were called upon to do would be done in the highest traditions of the Army; all we requested was a fair chance of survival and success for our men, and the minimum amount of warm clothing and supplies.'

Even at the initial stages, Umrao Singh had spelt out his misgivings of hustling 7 Brigade into what he considered to be a death trap. XXXIII Corps had suggested withdrawing the Dhola post to Tsangdhar, which was the alignment of the boundary marked on the map. However, should that not be acceptable for political reasons, Umrao had suggested that two battalions be kept in support south of Tsangdhar with the sole purpose of stopping any ingress by the Chinese. Bogey Sen, the Eastern Army Commander, had simply ignored the objections and reconfirmed his earlier orders.

Back in Shillong, the BGS XXXIII Corps and his staff prepared a fresh assessment based on the corps commander's observations during his visit to Lumpu. Relations between Umrao and Bogey Sen were strained ever since the earlier snub given to the corps by the command. Nevertheless, Jagjit Singh Aurora worked out a detailed appreciation that was brutally honest. Once again, unable to break established procedures, it had to be channelled through Eastern Command.

Bogey Sen was openly letting it be known that in his opinion, his three commanders on the ground (Umrao, Prasad and Dalvi) lacked 'fire in their bellies'. Both the Dalvi-Prasad appreciation and the Umrao Singh report reached Eastern Command within a day of each other. Bogey Sen decided to ignore the first part of the Dalvi-Prasad report, focusing only on the section that talked of moving troops up the Nam Ka Chu and then